EL NIÑO ACTION BRIEFING · 11 OCTOBER 2026

# Cecil Township, Washington County, Pennsylvania

*In Cecil, a strong El Niño has meant a milder, drier winter on average, but not a safe one. Seven of the last nine strong El Niño winters still brought a hard three-day freeze, and 2009–10 brought about two meters of snow. The people at risk are older residents living alone in the old coal-patch villages, and households that reach December with an unpaid heating bill or an empty oil tank. The most important steps come before December 1: get income on file with the utility and heating-assistance claims ready for November 2, build a list of who lives alone, and put a carbon monoxide alarm in every home a volunteer visits.*

| IMPACT REGION | EXCESS HEAT DEATHS | WINDOW | DOMINANT HAZARD |
|---|---|---|---|
| The Climate Impact Lab region containing Washington County, PA (inferred; not resolved in the tool) | No figure published for the US, Pennsylvania, or the county | Jun 2026 – Feb 2027 (heat only; not this hazard) | Short hard freezes and heating costs; power outages and carbon monoxide; a fat-tailed big-snow risk; flu and RSV; creek flooding (mainly outside winter) |

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY — AT A GLANCE




40.32°N 80.20°W, United States of America · Natural Earth

- **The risk.** Strong El Niño winters here are milder on average, but not safe: seven of the last nine still brought a hard three-day freeze, and 2009–10 brought about two meters of snow.
- **First action.** Before December 1, volunteers and the senior center help households get income on file with their utility, ready heating-assistance applications for November 2, and send oil and propane households to a crisis grant.
- **The money.** $78k floor, $215k target, $305k ceiling; spend the floor now on CO alarms and shutoff prevention, and hold the rest on a written trigger.
- **Do not.** Don't tell people "it'll be a mild El Niño winter": seven of nine strong El Niño winters still had a three-day hard freeze.


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|---|---|---|
| What to do | **15** actions | p. 5 |
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* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

**21/21 recommendations checked.** 1 confirmed, 11 corrected (partially confirmed), 3 unverified, and 6 contraindicated (one kept as a precaution on thin evidence). **The El Niño premise was tested, not assumed:** we classed 76 winters (1950–2025) of daily records from Pittsburgh International Airport, about 10 km north of the township, by the official El Niño index. The funding target fell 32% in verification, from $315k to $215k, just under the one-third mark at which this method flags a change: the Red Cross already installs free smoke alarms, Dollar Energy Fund pays bills but not furnaces, and the state weatherization program already replaces furnaces. **This briefing was researched with a reduced search budget.** The session's web-search allowance ran out early, so the panel and the verifiers worked mostly by fetching primary pages directly. Anything not fetched is marked unverified. **Exposure figure:** Climate Impact Lab, September 2026, pre-peer-review, publishes none for the US. Local figures are township- or county-level.

**Where this is.** Cecil Township is in northern Washington County, about 25 km southwest of downtown Pittsburgh, along Millers Run and Chartiers Creek and the I-79 corridor. It had 14,609 people in 2020. The township office is at 3599 Millers Run Road, Cecil 15321, and its villages include Bishop, Cowden, Hendersonville, Lawrence, Muse, Southview, Van Emman, and Venice. The Southpointe business park, home to the Greater Washington County Food Bank, is inside the township. Most homes are new (median year built 1996, against 1966 countywide), so the old, cold housing is concentrated in the former coal-patch villages. The township has three all-volunteer fire companies (Lawrence #1, Muse #2, and Cecil #3) and no paid fire service.

## DOES EL NIÑO MATTER HERE?

THE PREMISE, TESTED

Pittsburgh International Airport daily records (NOAA GHCN-Daily USW00094823), winters 1950–51 to 2025–26, classed by the CPC Oceanic Niño Index (peak of October–December, November–January, and December–February). Only nine winters were strong El Niños, so read every difference as a tilt, not a rule.

| WINTERS | DEC–FEB MEAN (°C) | NIGHTS AT OR BELOW −18 °C | WINTERS WITH A 3+ DAY RUN OF DAILY MEAN AT OR BELOW −7 °C | NOV–MAR SNOW (CM) | OCT–MAR PRECIPITATION (MM) | WINTERS WITH A 3-DAY TOTAL OF 75 MM OR MORE |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Strong El Niño (9)** | 0.5 | 0.8 | 7 of 9 | 86 | 391 | 0 of 9 |

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

| WINTERS | DEC–FEB MEAN (°C) | NIGHTS AT OR BELOW −18 °C | WINTERS WITH A 3+ DAY RUN OF DAILY MEAN AT OR BELOW −7 °C | NOV–MAR SNOW (CM) | OCT–MAR PRECIPITATION (MM) | WINTERS WITH A 3-DAY TOTAL OF 75 MM OR MORE |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Moderate or weak El Niño (18) | −1.6 | 3.4 | 14 of 18 | 103 | 406 | 0 of 18 |
| Neutral (22) | −1.1 | 3.6 | 19 of 22 | 114 | 420 | 4 of 22 |
| La Niña (27) | −0.7 | 2.2 | 19 of 27 | 108 | 460 | 4 of 27 |
| All (76) | −0.9 | 2.7 | 59 of 76 | 106 | 427 | 8 of 76 |

- **Strong El Niño winters here have been the mildest and driest.** They averaged 1.4 °C warmer than all winters, had a third as many −18 °C nights, about 20% less snow, and the least precipitation; none produced a three-day downpour of 75 mm.
- **The hard freeze still came.** Seven of the nine strong winters had a run of three or more days with a daily mean at or below −7 °C. That is the week that kills, and the average does not protect against it.
- **The big-snow tail is real.** 2009–10, a strong El Niño by this classing, brought about 197 cm of snow from November to March, roughly tied with 1950–51 as the snowiest in the airport record. On 5–6 February 2010, 21.9 inches fell at the airport, and about 8 more followed days later.
- **Rain is the weaker risk this winter.** Creek flooding here has come from a second storm on saturated ground, as in September 2004; a drier winter lowers those odds without removing them.

EXPOSURE, HONESTLY

## WHO DIES, AND WHY

- **An older minority, some of them alone.** 2,560 residents are 65 or over (17.2%, against 22.0% countywide), 197 are 85 or over, and 526 older residents live alone (ACS 2024 five-year estimates).
- **Heating fuel decides who is protected.** Of 6,209 occupied homes, 72% heat with utility gas and 566 (9%) with fuel oil. Pennsylvania's winter shutoff rule covers only regulated electric and gas utilities, so oil and propane households have no protection at all.
- **Winter deaths are recorded as heart and lung disease.** Almost nobody here will be recorded as dying of cold. Excess winter deaths come as heart attacks, COPD, and pneumonia, much of it driven by flu and RSV, which a mild winter does not reliably shrink. Lower heating prices have

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

measurably cut US winter deaths, mainly cardiovascular and respiratory, by about 12,500 a year after the late-2000s fall in gas prices (Chirakijja, Jayachandran & Ong).

- **Overdoses are the larger measured killer.** Washington County recorded 47 overdose deaths in 2025 and 57 in 2024, several times any plausible cold-attributed toll (county coroner, via the Observer-Reporter; not re-verified).
- **Food insecurity is already high.** More than 20,950 county residents are food-insecure, 30% of them older adults, and Washington County users of the Pittsburgh Food Bank network rose about 17.9% between July 2025 and June 2026.

HOW FOOD REACHES CECIL — SUPPLY CHAIN

The eighth lens. The honest finding is that El Niño's food signal here is noise; the chain breaks at the last few miles and at the benefit card.

- **Prices are not the problem.** USDA forecasts US grocery prices up 2.4% in 2026 and 1.8% in 2027, with a wide range (−5.0% to +9.2%) for 2027. Sugar and sweets (+6.6%) and coffee and cocoa are where an El Niño hit to tropical crops would show; they are a small share of a low-income food budget.
- **The benefit card is the fragile link.** Pennsylvania stopped issuing SNAP benefits from 16 October 2025 during the federal shutdown, until it ended. From 1 November 2025, adults 18 to 64 without a child under 14 must log 80 hours a month of work, volunteering, or training or lose benefits after three months in three years; exemptions for veterans and young people leaving foster care were removed, and the state no longer qualifies for local waivers.
- **Every link depends on a car and a road.** Supermarkets are outside the township's villages, reached over steep secondary roads. Whether any Cecil tract is low-income and low-access in USDA's atlas could not be checked.
- **Senior meals hang on donors.** Federal cuts ended the senior "Grab and Go" meals in Washington, Fayette, and Greene counties in February 2025. A donor-funded "Meals to Go" pilot restarted in October 2025 at the Cecil Township and Canonsburg senior centers: $5 a meal, free if you cannot pay, funded by EQT ($6,000) and a local car dealer ($4,000). Seniors can collect meals for homebound neighbors.
- **The food bank's route already reaches the homebound.** The Greater Washington County Food Bank distributed more than 1.8 million pounds last year through 10 pantries, 18 senior-box sites, and 15 senior high-rises, with DoorDash delivering senior boxes. Senior boxes are a monthly ration, not an emergency stock.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

The first five actions carry most of the expected deaths and should be done before December 1. Actions 6 to 9 protect food and money through the winter. Actions 10 to 15 cover snow, flood, outages, and monitoring.

## 1. Before December 1, get households' income on file with their utility so the winter shutoff rule protects them; have heating-assistance applications ready for November 2; and send oil and propane households to a crisis grant before the tank runs low

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED · ECONOMIST · SKEPTIC · PUBLIC HEALTH · PHILANTHROPIST · FRONTLINE · ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT QUERIED

| OWNER | BY WHEN | COST | PREVENTS |
|---|---|---|---|
| Volunteers and the senior center help households file; PA DHS (LIHEAP) and Dollar Energy Fund pay; utilities record income | Income on file by Dec 1; applications from Nov 2 | Volunteer time; grants paid by LIHEAP and utility hardship funds | A shutoff or an empty tank in the week of a hard freeze |

From December 1 to March 31, regulated electric and gas utilities may not shut off households at or below 250% of the federal poverty level, unless the PUC authorizes it (52 Pa. Code §56.100). Households above that line, and those that never proved their income, can be cut off, and October and November are open season. Pennsylvania's 2026–27 LIHEAP season opens November 2: cash grants of $200 to $1,000, an income limit of $49,500 for a household of four, and crisis grants for a shutoff notice or less than 15 days of fuel. Dollar Energy Fund's hardship grants ($500–600, once per utility per year, for incomes up to 250% of poverty) are open through September 2027; applicants must try LIHEAP first while it is open.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Corrections: the shutoff rule is a default, not a ban, which is why the income paperwork matters. Dollar Energy pays utility bills only, so the 566 oil-heated homes are reached only through LIHEAP crisis grants; no other channel for them was found. Which electric and gas utilities serve each part of the township was not confirmed. Last year, 90% of federal LIHEAP money reached the states only on 28 November 2025; this year's federal status was not confirmed.

## 2. Build a list of who lives alone by November 15, through the senior meals line, the Area Agency on Aging, and paper sign-ups for the township's alert system, and have volunteers phone everyone on it when a hard freeze is forecast

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | FRONTLINE · EMERGENCY MGR · PUBLIC HEALTH · SKEPTIC | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT QUERIED

| OWNER | BY WHEN | COST | TRIGGER |
|---|---|---|---|
| Cecil Township emergency management with the three fire companies and the McDonald Cecil Senior Center; Southwestern PA Area Agency on Aging | List by Nov 15; calls on every hard-freeze forecast | Volunteer time | NWS Pittsburgh forecast of three or more days with a daily mean at or below −7 °C (a locally chosen threshold) |

526 older residents live alone. The township's CivicReady alerts reach only people who sign up online, and there is no paper or phone route, so the oldest residents in Muse, Hendersonville, and Lawrence are the least likely to be on it. Volunteers can sign people up in person at fire-hall breakfasts and at the senior center, and adopt five homebound neighbors each. On each call, note the heating fuel, whether there is a CO alarm, and any medical equipment that needs power. After Hurricane Ivan in 2004, the county took days to learn who had died; a list built in November is what makes a house-by-house check possible in the dark.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Corrections: utilities and 911 will not hand over their lists of medically vulnerable customers for privacy reasons, so ask them to call their own flagged customers when the trigger hits. No study shows that check-in calls reduce cold deaths; the case rests on the Texas 2021 record, where hypothermia at home, mostly among people over 60, was the largest cause of death.

### 3. Have the fire companies install battery carbon monoxide alarms in older and low-income homes with gas or oil appliances, and pair every generator warning with advice on staying warm at home

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MGR · SKEPTIC · PUBLIC HEALTH · PHILANTHROPIST · FRONTLINE | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT QUERIED

| OWNER | BY WHEN | COST | PREVENTS |
|---|---|---|---|
| Lawrence, Muse, and Cecil volunteer fire companies; American Red Cross for smoke alarms | Installs by Dec 1; messages pre-written and sent on an outage or a grid emergency | ~$15k for 400 CO alarms (see funding) | CO deaths, which arrive with the outage, not the storm |

In New Mexico, about half of non-fire CO deaths over 16 years might have been prevented by detectors (Yoon et al. 1998). In Texas's February 2021 storm, 19 of 246 deaths were CO poisoning, from generators, grills, heaters, cars running in enclosed spaces, and ice blocking vents, and there were more than 1,400 emergency visits for CO, 42% of them children; but 158 deaths (64%) were hypothermia, which is why CO advice has to come with advice on keeping warm. The messages: never run a generator in a garage, even with the door open; never idle a car in an attached garage; no grills or camp stoves indoors. Pennsylvania law does not require CO alarms in existing owner-occupied homes (Act 121 of 2013 requires them in multifamily rentals with fossil-fuel appliances and disclosure at sale), so this fills a real gap.*

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Corrections: the Red Cross's Sound the Alarm program already installs free smoke alarms in southwestern Pennsylvania, so donor money should buy CO alarms only. The CO-alarm unit cost (~$35) is an assumption. The claim that no New Mexico decedent had an alarm is not in the study's abstract and is dropped.

## 4. Bring flu and RSV vaccines to the fire halls and the senior center, starting with older residents who live alone: high-dose or adjuvanted flu vaccine for everyone 65 and over, and one lifetime dose of RSV vaccine for everyone 75 and over and higher-risk adults 60 to 74

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | PUBLIC HEALTH | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT QUERIED

| OWNER | BY WHEN | COST | PREVENTS |
|---|---|---|---|
| Local pharmacies and primary care, with the senior center and fire companies hosting | October to December | Covered by Medicare and insurers; host time | Flu and RSV hospitalizations, the main driver of excess winter deaths here |

High-dose flu vaccine gave 24.2% more protection against laboratory-confirmed flu than the standard dose in 31,989 adults 65 and over (DiazGranados et al. 2014). RSV vaccine was 82.6% effective against RSV lower-respiratory disease in adults 60 and over (Papi et al. 2023). A milder El Niño winter does not reliably shrink the virus season, so vaccinate as for a normal winter.*

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Corrections: a 2026 meta-analysis of eight trials found high-dose vaccine cut flu hospitalizations but had no significant effect on all-cause deaths, so no deaths averted are claimed. The large observational estimate of a 48% fall in deaths (Nichol 2007) is inflated by healthy-user bias. RSV vaccine is a single dose, not yearly; the current age guidance could not be re-checked on CDC pages. Washington County vaccine uptake was not found.

## 5. Name the three fire halls as warming and charging points, load-test their generators and the township building's for four hours, sign a priority refueling agreement, and offer rides

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MGR · FRONTLINE · SKEPTIC | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT QUERIED

| OWNER | BY WHEN | COST | PREVENTS |
|---|---|---|---|
| Cecil Township emergency management with the fire companies | Nov 30 | ~$2–5k fuel (estimate) | A warming site that fails on day two of a multi-day outage |

In Winter Storm Elliott (December 2022), 24% of the regional grid's generating capacity was forced offline, about 70% of it gas plants, and demand response delivered only 1,100 MW of 4,336 MW expected; Pittsburgh hit a record −5 °F on December 24. People will walk into a fire hall they went to as children before they will go to a county shelter. Publish the list in church bulletins and on fridge magnets.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Corrections: each hall's generator capacity was not confirmed. Warming sites are a backstop, not the plan: most people will stay home, and in Texas refusing to move to heated shelters was a hypothermia risk factor, so the ride offer and the phone list (action 2) carry more weight.

## 6. Add a three-to-five-day no-cook food shelf to the food bank's senior-box and DoorDash route for homebound seniors before January

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | FOOD SUPPLY · FRONTLINE · HISTORIAN · SKEPTIC | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT QUERIED

| OWNER | BY WHEN | COST | PREVENTS |
|---|---|---|---|
| Greater Washington County Food Bank with the Area Agency on Aging and the Meals to Go donors | December | ~$40 a kit (estimate, unverified); needs separate funding | A homebound senior running out of food in a snowed-in week on a hillside road |

The delivery route already exists: senior boxes go to 18 sites and 15 high-rises, and DoorDash delivers to homebound seniors. In February 2010 one storm closed hill roads for days. No-cook food matters because an outage kills electric stoves and pushes people toward grills and camp stoves indoors.

Corrections: senior boxes are a monthly ration, so the emergency shelf needs its own money. The kit cost is unverified.

## 7. From November to January, help pantry clients aged 18 to 64 check for remaining SNAP exemptions and log their 80 hours a month

CONFIRMED | FOOD SUPPLY · PUBLIC HEALTH | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT QUERIED

| OWNER | BY WHEN | COST | PREVENTS |
|---|---|---|---|
| Greater Washington County Food Bank and pantries, with Cecil Township | Nov–Jan | Staff and volunteer time | A quiet loss of food income larger than any El Niño price effect |

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Since November 1, 2025, adults 18 to 64 without a child under 14 must log 80 hours a month or lose SNAP after three months in three years; veterans and young people leaving foster care lost their exemptions, and Pennsylvania no longer qualifies for local waivers. The rule covers working-age adults, not only those over 50.

## 8. Hold a cold-snap and outage reserve at the Washington County Community Foundation, released on a written trigger for warming rooms, generator fuel, and hotel nights

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | PHILANTHROPIST · ECONOMIST | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: ANTICIPATORY CASH (PRECEDENTS OUTSIDE THE US)

| OWNER | BY WHEN | COST | TRIGGER |
|---|---|---|---|
| Washington County Community Foundation, "Close to Home" Disaster and Emergency Fund | Trigger agreed by Dec 1 | $75k (see funding) | NWS Pittsburgh forecast of three or more days at a daily mean of −7 °C or below, or a multi-day outage |

The El Niño tilt lowers the expected toll, so not all the money should be spent in October; deaths come in the cold-snap and big-snow tail. A three-day outage for 100 households costs roughly $45,000 in hotel nights (100 × 3 nights × $150) before warming rooms and fuel. Seven of nine strong El Niño winters had a run that would have met this trigger.

Corrections: the −7 °C threshold is a locally chosen number with no official source. The fund's size and grant record could not be checked.

## 9. Before committing Marcellus impact-fee money as a heating bridge, confirm the township's balance and get a solicitor's view that the use is lawful

UNVERIFIED | ECONOMIST | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT QUERIED

| OWNER | BY WHEN | COST | TRIGGER |
|---|---|---|---|
| Cecil Township supervisors and solicitor | November | ~$25k (arithmetic: 50 households × $500), not a costing | The state announces that LIHEAP crisis funds are exhausted |

Act 13 lets municipalities spend impact fees on emergency preparedness and public safety and on social services (58 Pa.C.S. §2314(g)), each "associated with natural gas production from unconventional gas wells". A township float can bridge the gap if federal heating money runs out mid-winter.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Unverified: Cecil's 2025 impact-fee amount could not be retrieved (the PUC report viewer failed), and the "associated with" qualifier needs legal reading. A trigger based on the federal release date is weak, because Pennsylvania opens on November 2 regardless.

## 10. Fill the salt barns by December 1, renew plow mutual aid with neighboring townships, agree the order of township roads near the I-79 interchanges, and line up snow-shoveling help for older men on big-snow days

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MGR · PUBLIC HEALTH | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT QUERIED

| OWNER | BY WHEN | COST | PREVENTS |
|---|---|---|---|
| Cecil Township public works; youth groups and churches for shoveling | Dec 1 | Budgeted salt bought early; volunteer time | Roads closing for days in a 2010-type month; heart attacks while shoveling |

In Quebec, 20 cm of snow was followed the next day by 16% higher odds of heart-attack admission and 34% higher odds of heart-attack death in men, with no association in women (Auger et al. 2017, observational).

Corrections: I-79 itself is PennDOT's responsibility; the township's part is its connector roads. Present this as low-regret preparation, not a forecast of heavy snow.

## 11. Set a flood trigger on the Chartiers Creek gauge at Carnegie, list the mobile-home parks in the floodplain, and record Cecil's own high-water marks and addresses for future flood-mitigation grants; flood insurance is a lower priority this winter

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MGR · HISTORIAN · ECONOMIST | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT QUERIED

| OWNER | BY WHEN | COST | PREVENTS |
|---|---|---|---|
| Cecil Township emergency management with Washington County EMA | Dec 15 | Staff time | A repeat of 2004, when mobile homes took most of the losses |

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

On September 17, 2004, Hurricane Ivan's remnants dropped up to six inches of rain on ground already soaked by Frances, and creeks flooded from Peters and Cecil townships to Canton, Chartiers, and Smith. Washington County lost 100 mobile homes, 25 single-family homes, one multifamily home, and four businesses; FEMA paid $4.59 million. Downstream, one man died in Carnegie. Cecil's own damage is not documented online, which is itself the reason to write it down now.

Corrections: no gauge on Millers Run was found, so the Carnegie gauge (USGS 03085500, NWS CARP1) is a downstream proxy and Millers Run points must be marked by hand. FEMA mitigation grants need an adopted county hazard-mitigation plan, whose status was not confirmed. The NFIP waiting period and Cecil's policy count were not checked.

## 12. Agree a pledge or line of credit with United Way and the county commissioners for the food bank, to be drawn if SNAP is delayed again

UNVERIFIED | FOOD SUPPLY | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT QUERIED

| OWNER | BY WHEN | COST | TRIGGER |
|---|---|---|---|
| United Way of Washington County and the county commissioners | December | Size from the food bank's October–November 2025 surge data | A SNAP issuance delay |

The October 2025 suspension of SNAP is the precedent. A pledge costs nothing unless it is drawn.

Unverified: the lens's $100,000 figure has no source and is not used. It is not a funding placement here.

## 13. Before an outage, cross-match the meals roster with the utilities' medical-certificate holders so that people with medicines, oxygen, or food that needs refrigeration get ice, a cooler, or a priority restore

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | FOOD SUPPLY · EMERGENCY MGR | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT QUERIED

| OWNER | BY WHEN | COST | PREVENTS |
|---|---|---|---|
| Area Agency on Aging and meal providers; utilities call their own certificate holders | Dec 1 | Minimal | Spoiled insulin and food in a multi-day outage |

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Pennsylvania utilities hold medical certificates for customers whose health depends on power. The ice-storm and outage risk is moderate in a milder El Niño winter, but the grid came close to rolling blackouts in December 2022.

Corrections: the utilities will not share the certificate list, so they make the calls. The certificate rules were not fetched.

## 14. Watch three signals monthly: Northeast-region grocery prices, Washington County's SNAP caseload, and the food bank's weekly pantry visits

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | FOOD SUPPLY | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT QUERIED

| OWNER | BY WHEN | COST | PREVENTS |
|---|---|---|---|
| Greater Washington County Food Bank with the county | Monthly through March | Staff time | Pantries running empty before anyone notices the demand |

Proposed signals: the BLS Northeast-region food-at-home index above 4% year on year (monthly); Washington County SNAP cases falling more than 5% in a quarter, which would signal people dropping off under the work rule rather than rising incomes; and pantry visits up 15% on the same week a year earlier.

Corrections: BLS stopped publishing a Pittsburgh index after 2017, so the regional series replaces it. Whether DHS publishes county caseloads monthly was not checked.

## 15. Keep naloxone distribution running through the winter in the villages

UNVERIFIED | PUBLIC HEALTH | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT QUERIED

| OWNER | BY WHEN | COST | PREVENTS |
|---|---|---|---|
| Washington County drug and alcohol services, pharmacies, and fire companies | Ongoing | Within existing programs | Overdose deaths, the largest measured cause of avoidable death here |

Washington County's overdose deaths (47 in 2025, 57 in 2024) outnumber any plausible cold toll. This is continuity of service, not El Niño preparation, but the same volunteers will be at the same doors.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Unverified: no primary source on local naloxone distribution was fetched, and the overdose counts were not re-checked.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

**R** = Responsible (does the work) · **A** = Accountable (one per action; signs off and answers for it) · **C** = Consulted (asked before) · **I** = Informed (told after). Built from the owners named in the verified actions. No one here has been contacted or has agreed to a role; every row is a proposal.

| Action | Township emergency mgmt & supervisors | Fire companies | Senior center & Area Agency on Aging | Food bank & pantries | PA DHS (LIHEAP, SNAP) | Utilities & Dollar Energy | Red Cross | Community Foundation & United Way | County EMA & commissioners | Pharmacies & health | PennDOT |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1. Income on file; heating claims; oil crisis grants | C | R | R | R | A/R | R | | | I | | |
| 2. Who-lives-alone list; freeze calls | A/R | R | R | C | | R | | | I | | |
| 3. CO alarms; generator and warmth messages | C | A/R | R | | | | R | C | I | | |
| 4. Flu and RSV vaccines at halls and center | I | R | R | | | | | | | A/R | |
| 5. Fire halls as warming points; generators | A/R | R | C | | | C | | | C | | |
| 6. No-cook food shelf for homebound seniors | | | R | A/R | | | | C | | | |
| 7. SNAP exemption and hours help | R | | C | A/R | C | | | | | | |
| 8. Cold-snap and outage reserve | C | C | | | | | | A/R | C | | |
| 9. Impact-fee heating bridge | A/R | | | | I | C | | | | | |
| 10. Salt, plows, roads; shoveling help | A/R | C | C | | | | | | C | | C |
| 11. Flood trigger; mobile homes; high-water marks | A/R | R | | | | | | | R | | |
| 12. Food bank pledge for a SNAP delay | | | | C | I | | | R | A/R | | |
| 13. Outage medicine and refrigeration list | C | | A/R | | | R | | | | C | |
| 14. Prices, caseload, and pantry signals | | | | A/R | C | | | | I | | |
| 15. Naloxone continuity | | R | | | | | | | C | A/R | |

What the chart shows: **township emergency management is accountable for six rows**, and most need a list, a test, or a decision rather than money. **The three volunteer fire companies are responsible for eight rows** and accountable for one; they are the township's real civic infrastructure, so overloading them is the main delivery risk. Nobody is accountable for the 566 oil-heated homes beyond the state's crisis grant.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Verified and corrected. Spend the floor now on things that pay off in any winter: CO alarms and shutoff prevention. Hold the rest on a written trigger for the cold snap or outage that actually kills.

| FLOOR | TARGET | CEILING | LARGEST UNCERTAINTY |
|---|---|---|---|
| $78k | $215k | $305k | Whether federal heating assistance is funded this winter; and no channel exists for oil-heated homes |

**Arithmetic.** Floor: 300 CO alarms × $35 = $10,500 + 150 households × $450 shutoff gap = $67,500, for **$78,000**. Target: CO alarms 400 × $35 + ~$1,000 overhead = $15,000; Dollar Energy Fund 150 households × $600 = $90,000; meals and wellness calls for the 10 peak weeks, 100 people × 10 weeks × 5 meals × $7 = $35,000; cold-snap and outage reserve $75,000; total **$215,000**. Ceiling: target + 15 furnace replacements × $6,000 = $90,000 for households on the weatherization waitlist or just above its income limit, for **$305,000**. The target fell 32% from the panel's $315,000: smoke alarms are already free through the Red Cross, Dollar Energy pays bills but not furnaces, the meals line was cut to the peak weeks, and the reserve was sized to a three-day outage. The CO-alarm cost, the $7 meal, and the $450 shutoff gap are assumptions.

| RECIPIENT | USE | AMOUNT | MECHANISM | BASIS | VERDICT |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Lawrence, Muse, and Cecil volunteer fire companies | Action 3: CO alarms fitted in ~400 homes | $15k | Restricted grant | About half of non-fire CO deaths judged preventable by detectors (Yoon et al. 1998, New Mexico); smoke alarms already free through the Red Cross | Partially confirmed |
| Dollar Energy Fund (EIN 25-1442933), restricted to Washington County | Action 1: shutoff prevention after LIHEAP | $90k | Donor-restricted fund | $500–600 grants; spent $24.7M in 2023; heating prices causally raise US winter deaths (Chirakijja, Jayachandran & Ong) | Partially confirmed |
| Southwestern PA Area Agency on Aging and the McDonald Cecil Senior Center | Action 2: meals and wellness calls for older residents living alone, Dec–Feb | $35k | Direct grant | Home-delivered meals linked to fewer nursing-home admissions (Thomas & Mor 2013), not to cold deaths; the senior center's pages could not be fetched | Partially confirmed |

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

| RECIPIENT | USE | AMOUNT | MECHANISM | BASIS | VERDICT |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Washington County Community Foundation, Close to Home fund | Action 8: cold-snap and outage reserve | $75k | Pre-positioned reserve on a trigger | Sized to a three-day outage; fund's size and record not checked | Partially confirmed |
| Weatherization provider, to be named | Furnace top-up for households on the waitlist | $0 (ceiling $90k) | Restricted grant | PA Weatherization Assistance Program already replaces heating systems at or below 200% of poverty (~$8,547 a home) | Partially confirmed |
| No recipient found | Oil and propane households beyond the LIHEAP crisis grant | $0 | — | Dollar Energy covers regulated utilities only | Gap |

**The funder's one thing:** El Niño makes the average winter here milder and should lower the expected toll, so don't spend the whole envelope in October. Spend the floor on CO alarms and shutoff prevention, which pay off in any winter, and hold the rest for the week that comes anyway. The cheapest life saved is an 80-year-old widow in Muse whose gas account has her income on file and whose kitchen has a $35 alarm.

## Do not do this

CONTRAINDICATED · ADVICE THAT WOULD COST LIVES HERE

Advice that circulates for this hazard and would cost lives, money, or trust here.

### Don't tell people "it'll be a mild El Niño winter"

CONTRAINDICATED SKEPTIC

The average strong El Niño winter here has been mild, but seven of nine still had a three-day hard freeze, and 2009–10 brought about two meters of snow. A warm-sounding forecast invites households to skip a propane or oil fill, let arrears build through October and November before the shutoff rule starts, and put off the heating-assistance claim. No study was found showing that mild forecasts reduce preparedness, so this rests on the record and the mechanism.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

**Instead:** "The average will be mild; the week that kills won't be. Sort your utility account before December 1."

## Don't give generator advice on its own *

CONTRAINDICATED SKEPTIC · EMERGENCY MGR

In Texas in February 2021, 19 people died of CO poisoning from generators, grills, heaters, cars, and blocked vents, and more than 1,400 people went to emergency or urgent care for CO. In Houston a woman and her daughter died with a car running in an attached garage; in Austin a family brought a charcoal grill indoors.

**Instead:** a battery CO alarm with every generator message, plus "never in a garage, even with the door open; never idle a car in an attached garage; no grills or camp stoves indoors" (action 3).

## Don't suggest a space heater to cut the heating bill *

CONTRAINDICATED SKEPTIC

Portable heaters were 3% of home heating fires but 41% of fatal heating fires in 2017–19 (US Fire Administration). Ten Texas storm deaths were fire-related, including space heaters near flammable items.

**Instead:** keep three feet clear around any heater, don't use extension cords on appliances, check smoke alarms, and refer the home for weatherization.

## Don't tell people "you're protected from shutoff in winter"

CONTRAINDICATED SKEPTIC · ECONOMIST

The protection runs only from December 1 to March 31, only for households at or below 250% of poverty whose income the utility knows, and only for regulated electric and gas. Oil and propane have no protection, the PUC can still authorize a shutoff, and fraud or tampering allows an immediate one.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

**Instead:** get income on file with the utility now, enroll in its assistance program, and file a heating-assistance crisis claim from November 2 while the shutoff notice or the low tank is still a warning (action 1).

### Don't make warming centers the main plan in a township without transit *

CONTRAINDICATED SKEPTIC

In Texas's 2021 storm, 64% of deaths were hypothermia, 68% of those among people over 60, and refusing to move to heated shelters was listed as a risk factor: people die at home even when shelters exist. Cecil's oldest residents live on hillside roads in villages without public transit.

**Instead:** the phone list and a knock (action 2), rides to the fire halls (action 5), and a plan for most people to stay warm at home.

### Don't hand out "72-hour kit" lists or food that needs cooking *

CONTRAINDICATED · PRECAUTION SKEPTIC

"Stock up" assumes spare cash, and food that needs cooking pushes people toward grills and stoves indoors when the power is out. This rests on reasoning and the Texas grill deaths, not on a study.

**Instead:** no-cook, shelf-stable food delivered to the people who need it (action 6), and a short list of named low-cost items: a CO alarm, a flashlight, and blankets.

WHAT HAS HAPPENED HERE BEFORE THE RECORD

| YEAR | EVENT | TOLL | WHAT CHANGED AFTER |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1936 (March) | St. Patrick's Day flood, western Pennsylvania | At least 69 dead, 45 in Pittsburgh | Flood Control Acts of 1936 and 1938; dams built for the rivers, not for Millers Run or upper Chartiers Creek |

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

| YEAR | EVENT | TOLL | WHAT CHANGED AFTER |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1948 (October) | Donora smog, Washington County: a temperature inversion trapped industrial smoke for four days | 20 dead, about 50 more within a month | The start of US clean-air law |
| 1950 (November) | Great Appalachian Storm | Heavy snow; Pittsburgh's total not confirmed here | — |
| 1957–2023 | Nine strong El Niño winters | Mildest and driest class at the airport; 7 of 9 still had a three-day hard freeze | — |
| 2004 (17 September) | Hurricane Ivan's remnants on ground soaked by Frances; creeks flood from Peters and Cecil townships | Washington County: 100 mobile homes, 25 single-family homes, 4 businesses lost; one death downstream in Carnegie; FEMA $4.59M | Cecil's own damage was never documented online |
| 2010 (February) | Back-to-back snowstorms in a strong El Niño winter | 21.9 in at the airport on 5–6 February and about 8 more days later; about 197 cm for the season | — |
| 2022 (December) | Winter Storm Elliott | Pittsburgh −5 °F, a record; 24% of the regional grid's capacity forced offline | The grid avoided rolling blackouts, narrowly |
| 2025 | Federal cuts end senior "Grab and Go" meals (February); SNAP suspended during the shutdown (October); SNAP work rules expanded (November) | About 450 seniors across three counties lost meals (headline figure) | Donor-funded Meals to Go restarts at the Cecil Township senior center (October) |

**The recurrence nobody has noticed:** every big rescue here followed a storm on ground already wet from an earlier one, Frances before Ivan, and snowmelt in 1936. Flood control was built for Pittsburgh's rivers, and the creeks through Cecil were left to their residents. A milder, drier El Niño winter lowers the odds but does not reset the ground; watch for the second storm, especially in a wet early spring.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

## WHERE THE EXPERTS DISAGREE — RESOLVED AND OPEN

- **Resolved: spend now or hold back.** The Philanthropist said to hold most of the money for the cold snap; Public Health and the Skeptic warned that a "mild winter" framing underinvests where deaths actually are (flu, and the one bad week). Resolved as: spend the floor now on things that work in any winter, hold the reserve on a written trigger, and never tell residents it will be mild.
- **Resolved: smoke alarms or CO alarms.** The panel proposed combination alarms; verification found the Red Cross already installs free smoke alarms here, so donor money buys CO alarms only.
- **Open: what reaches the oil-heated homes.** 566 homes heat with fuel oil, outside the shutoff rule and outside Dollar Energy Fund. Only the state's crisis grant reaches them, and no lens found a local channel.
- **Open: does a heating-bridge fund from impact fees fit Act 13?** The statute allows emergency preparedness and social services "associated with" gas production; a solicitor has to say whether heating help qualifies.
- **Open: the size of the winter death burden.** Public Health extrapolated about 10 excess winter deaths a year in the township and 250 in the county; that is modeled arithmetic, not a count, and this report does not rely on it.

## WHAT NOBODY COVERED — BLIND SPOT

**The people outside every list, and the research the search limit cut short.** No lens could confirm whether any part of the township is a food desert, which utilities serve which villages, the township's impact-fee balance, the county's vaccine uptake, or whether the county's hazard-mitigation plan is current. Renters in older village housing, people without a phone, and anyone who doesn't speak English were not reached by any source. A morning of phone calls to the township office, the senior center, the food bank, and the three fire companies would close most of these gaps.

## HOW TO READ THIS — METHOD

**The panel is author-built.** Eight simulated expert lenses were used to generate these recommendations. Where they agree, that is a strong hypothesis, not a consensus of the field. Every recommendation was then independently checked for evidence, transferability to this location, and feasibility before the peak; the verdict tags carry the result.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Mortality figures are resolved at Climate Impact Lab impact-region scale, roughly 300,000 people. They are not neighborhood figures. The El Niño projection covers *heat only*; cold, snow, outages, carbon monoxide, flu, and flooding are additional to it and are carried here by the station record and the historical record rather than by a published number.

## HOW THIS BRIEFING WAS PRODUCED

METHODOLOGY

- **Scope.** The request was "Cecil, PA", taken as Cecil Township, Washington County (Cecil County is in Maryland). Climate Impact Lab impact region: the region containing Washington County, inferred, not resolved. Local statistics are township-level (ACS 2024 five-year) where available, otherwise county-level.
- **Exposure.** Climate Impact Lab, *451,000 at Risk* (September 2026, pre-peer-review): ECMWF SEAS5 seasonal forecasts (51-member ensemble) applied to temperature–mortality relationships across 24,378 regions, against a 1996–2025 baseline, for June 2026 – February 2027. It covers heat only and gives no US figure. It is never added to the Impact Map's long-run projections.
- **Premise test.** NOAA GHCN-Daily records for Pittsburgh International Airport (USW00094823), 76 winters 1950–51 to 2025–26 with at least 90% of days reported, quality-flagged values excluded, classed by the CPC Oceanic Niño Index peak over October–December, November–January, and December–February (strong: 1.5 or above).
- **Expert panel.** Eight simulated expert lenses (emergency manager, public health scientist, frontline responder, skeptic, economist, historian, philanthropist, and food supply chain analyst) each researched Cecil independently and in parallel, from web sources, to a fixed brief that included the premise test. The Cleveland, Ohio briefing was used as a regional comparison.
- **Reconciliation.** Duplicate actions were merged and backing lenses recorded. Convergence was tested for shared bias before it counted in an action's favor; the converged actions (income on file, a who-lives-alone list, CO alarms) rest on Pennsylvania law and local records rather than on borrowed studies. Contradictions were kept. Each action was given a payer and trigger or marked unfunded, and the funding placements were reconciled against the ranked list.
- **Verification.** Six verifier agents checked the health and CO actions, the money and utility actions, the operational actions and historical record, the food actions, the funding envelope, and the contraindicated items, on evidence, transferability, and feasibility, by fetching the Pennsylvania Code, PA DHS, the LIHEAP Clearinghouse, PJM, EIA, USDA ERS, the Census Bureau, Europe PMC abstracts, Texas DSHS, and local news directly. Financial actions were checked for availability, payer, trigger, and redundancy. The envelope was re-summed.
- **Verdicts.** *Confirmed*: evidence, transferability, and feasibility all hold. *Partially confirmed*: holds after the corrections shown. *Unverified*: could not be checked to a primary source. *Contraindicated*: would do harm or waste the window here.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

- **Adaptation Inventory.** Not queried in this run; its listings load by JavaScript. Every action is tagged "not queried".
- **Health wording.** Passages where a wording error could hurt someone (vaccines and doses, carbon monoxide, generators, grills, and space heaters, cold for older people, and cooking in an outage) are marked "* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing." They were checked against published sources, not by a health professional. They are suggestions, not medical advice, and anyone passing them on should confirm them with a doctor, pharmacist, nurse, or community health worker first. The marker was added on 2 November 2026.
- **Rules.** No cost is derived by dividing a published total. Assumed unit costs are labeled, and arithmetic is shown.
- **Limits.** The panel and verifiers are AI research agents working from web-available sources, not human experts, and no one in Cecil was interviewed. **The session's web-search allowance ran out early in this run**, so most research and all verification relied on directly fetched pages; claims that could not be fetched are marked unverified, and several local facts (pantry hours, utility territories, impact-fee amounts, vaccine uptake, the hazard-mitigation plan) remain open. CDC vaccine pages, the PUC impact-fee viewer, and two cooling-center studies could not be opened. The 1950 Pittsburgh snow total, the February 2010 monthly total, and the Bridgeville high-water mark were dropped as unverified.


References · verified in this run unless marked.

Premise: CPC Oceanic Niño Index (fetched) · GHCN-D Pittsburgh International Airport (fetched) · WPXI, February 2010 snow

Place and people: Cecil Township departments · CivicReady alerts · Cecil Township (secondary) · Lawrence Volunteer Fire Department · ACS 2024 five-year, via Census Reporter (heating fuel re-verified; age figures from the lens) · Observer-Reporter, overdose deaths (not re-verified)

Money and utilities: 52 Pa. Code §56.100 · PA DHS, LIHEAP · LIHEAP Clearinghouse, federal funding · Dollar Energy Fund 2026–27 · Dollar Energy hardship rules · Dollar Energy Fund filings (ProPublica) · PJM capacity auction 2027/28 · EIA Short-Term Energy Outlook, Oct 2026 · 58 Pa.C.S. §2314, Act 13 impact fees · PA Weatherization Assistance Program · Washington County Community Foundation · Southwestern PA Area Agency on Aging

Health and safety: DiazGranados et al. 2014 · Papi et al. 2023 · High-dose flu vaccine meta-analysis, 2026 · Nichol et al. 2007 · Yoon et al. 1998, CO deaths in New Mexico · US Fire Administration, heating fires · Texas DSHS, February 2021 storm deaths · ProPublica, Texas CO poisoning · PA Act 121 of 2013, CO alarms · Auger et al. 2017, snowfall and heart attacks · Chirakijja, Jayachandran & Ong, heating prices and mortality · Jowers et al. 2021, shutoff moratoria · Red Cross free smoke alarms, SW PA

Food: USDA ERS Food Price Outlook, Sep 2026 · Herald-Standard, food insecurity, Sep 2026 · CBS Pittsburgh, SNAP suspension and work rules · PA DHS, SNAP work requirements · Meals to Go restart, Oct 2025 · Greater Washington County Food Bank · BLS, Pittsburgh CPI discontinued

History and hazards: Observer-Reporter, Hurricane Ivan · WPXI, Ivan in Carnegie · Utility Dive, Winter Storm Elliott · December 2022 winter storm (secondary) · 1948 Donora smog (secondary) · 1936 Pittsburgh flood (secondary) · USGS 03085500, Chartiers Creek at Carnegie

Exposure data · Climate Impact Lab, 451,000 at Risk · Impact Map · Adaptation Inventory


* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Generated 11 October 2026 for Cecil Township, Washington County, Pennsylvania. El Niño Ready is volunteer-run and is not affiliated with Climate Week NYC, The Climate Group, or Columbia University.

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